

society & the arts ACTION MOVIES

Bollywood flexes its muscles as directors scour the world for martial arts coordinators, sword masters and car chase specialists to offer designer action to Indian audiences

Let's Get Physical

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Over the course of several chilly winter mornings in Delhi's crowded Chandni Chowk, Akshay Kumar, playing a pot-bellied vegetable-cutter with a moustache modelled on his co-producer Rohan Sippy's, was to be found leaping across cheek-by-jowl terraces framed by the majestic Red Fort. Watching his every move were two pairs of eagle eyes, one belonging to Huan-Chiu 'Dee Dee' Ku—a Hong Kong-based martial arts coordinator who has trained the god of eastern action, Jet Li, and worked on *Kill Bill*—and the other to Jenny, a six-foot-one-inch dancer-cum-trainer from Liverpool who works with the actor on parkour with her partner Daniel. Kumar, a martial arts enthusiast, parlays virtually his own story in the Rs 60-crore forthcoming film directed by Nikhil Advani, called *Chandni Chowk to China*, an action comedy that showcases the twin talents of Bollywood's actor-of-the-moment, whose four films last year grossed Rs 350 crore.

Over a cheery dinner on a balmy evening, where Advani extols the virtues of Kumar, who can do 36 shots in a single day without losing breath or concentration, Sippy makes a droll but precise comment: "Parkour is Bollywood's new item song." Indeed,

the complex obstacle race, first unveiled on the big screen in *Casino Royale*, is Kumar's current passion. He has built an obstacle course for himself and his five-year-old son, whose name is famously tattooed on his back. Action is certainly the new buzzword in Bollywood. As Tips producer Ramesh Taurani waits for the release of his Rs 42-crore *Race*, where Saif Ali Khan leaps off Durban buildings in what promises to be a slick mix of style and guile, he has already greenlit a script from a new director which involves parkour.

"It's not so much a physical challenge as it is a mental one," says Saif, shooting in Mumbai for Kunal Kohli's next romance.

"When you are leaping



SINGH IS KINNG

ACTION STATIONS Four stunts, including a sequence that has Akshay Kumar (above) jumping from one moving elevator to another, cost Rs 16 crore.

BUDGET
Rs 48 cr

FIGHT MASTER The Australian Danny Baldwin, who was the action choreographer on *The Ghost and the Darkness*.

from the 35th floor of a building, even when you trust the fact that the cables won't snap, it's frightening," he says. For the actor, who's better known for stretching his acting muscle, it's an experience he has repeated in *Tashan*, a forthcoming YashRaj Films production

whose action sequences are choreographed by the Vietnamese Peter Hain.

The search for sharper action sequences has seen Bollywood's brightest directors frenziedly logging on to *imdb.com*, a worldwide database of films. That's where Goldie Behl dis-